

Chicago Tribune



QUESTIONS? CALL 1-800-TRIBUNE

THURSDAY, FEBRUARY 13, 2025

BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

MICHAEL MADIGAN TRIAL

Guilty on 10 counts

Former Illinois House speaker convicted of bribery and corruption related to the use of his office to increase power

In split verdict, jurors deadlock on marquee racketeering decision and acquit 82-year-old on several other charges



Former Illinois Speaker of the House Michael Madigan, flanked by daughters Nicole, left, and Tiffany, leaves the Dirksen U.S. Courthouse on Wednesday. **E. JASON WAMBSGANS/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

After conviction, state Democrats try to move on as GOP lawmakers call for greater ethics reforms

By Jeremy Gorner, Olivia Olander, Rick Pearson and Dan Petrella
Chicago Tribune

Hoping to finally turn the page on former House Speaker Michael Madigan's decadeslong reign over Illinois politics, Democrats — many of whom spent years bowing to the speaker's power — cheered his conviction Wednesday on federal bribery conspiracy charges.

Republicans, meanwhile, sought to prevent their dominant rivals from running too far from the man who from the 1980s until his ouster in 2021 was the most powerful singular force in Springfield.

The long-awaited verdict came at an exceedingly awkward time in state and national politics. A federal jury convicted Madigan on just 10 of the nearly two

Turn to Reaction, Page 5

What's next?

The split verdict does not avert the possibility of a significant sentence for Michael Madigan, who turns 83 in April. Several of the guilty counts carry a maximum of 20 years in prison, according to the U.S. attorney's office. No date has been set for Madigan's sentencing. And acting U.S. Attorney Morris Pasqual said it was too soon to make a decision on seeking a retrial on some counts.

By Jason Meisner, Megan Crepeau and Ray Long
Chicago Tribune

Illinois House Speaker Michael Madigan minced no words on the day Democratic Gov. Rod Blagojevich, his longtime political nemesis, was arrested on federal corruption charges in December 2008.

"Today's events are shocking and disappointing," Madigan, the then-leader of the state Democratic Party, said on that infamous day 16 years ago. "It represents a new low for conduct by public officials."

At the time, Blagojevich was the latest in a depressing array of governors, state legislators, county commissioners and aldermen accused of selling out the public's trust for personal gain.

On Wednesday, a federal jury added Madigan to that same, sad parade.

In a verdict sure to reverberate across the political landscape, the jury found Madigan, once the most powerful politician in the state, guilty of bribery conspiracy and other corruption charges alleging

Turn to Madigan, Page 4

Ukraine may be shut out of Trump, Putin negotiations

By Matthew Lee, Will Weissert and Zeke Miller
Associated Press

WASHINGTON — President Donald Trump upended three years of U.S. policy toward Ukraine on Wednesday, saying that he and Russian leader Vladimir Putin had agreed to begin negotiations on ending the war following a sudden prisoner swap.

Trump said in a social media post that he and Putin held a lengthy phone call and committed to "work together, very closely" to bring the conflict to an end and would meet in person, including perhaps in each other's countries.

Trump subsequently announced that he'd also

Turn to Ukraine, Page 9



STACEY WESCOTT/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

The hills are alive, finally, with a little bit of snow

Ben Kamman, a Barrington middle schooler, slides down the sledding hill at Picnic Grove Park in Fox River Grove on Wednesday. The National Weather Service had issued a winter weather advisory for the Chicago area, with a prediction of 3 to 6 inches of snow, likely ending up as the snowiest storm so far this season.

\$100M gift sets sights on clean energy initiatives

By Karina Atkins
Chicago Tribune

The World Resources Institute and University of Chicago received a combined \$100 million donation Wednesday to accelerate the global clean energy transition.

The global nonprofit was given \$75 million to help communities overcome barriers to scaling clean, affordable and reliable power systems, while the university was given \$25 million to train the next generation of clean energy leaders.

The donations, endowed by Chicago-based philanthropists Michael and Tanya Polsky, come as President Donald Trump has sent the United States' clean energy

Turn to Gift, Page 5